hold the meeting with ULFA in either Guwahati or Calcutta, so that the IB would get an opportunity to nab Baruah. But the ULFA chief refused to meet anywhere except in Bangkok. The Tatas also made a request to the IB to send one of its officers to the meeting. This was, however, not acceded to.

Sehgal recalls that the Tatas and the IB worked together for many years to nab the ULFA leader. He encouraged the Tatas to continue with their policy of undertaking socially beneficial schemes. At the same time, he cautioned against any deviation from the company's policy of not giving any assistance, monetary or otherwise, to the militants. The group adhered to it in both letter and spirit and stood steadfast in following its policy.

On 25 May 1996, the Tata Tea officials met with Baruah at a hotel in Bangkok. During the meeting, Baruah demanded that Tata Tea provide his group with the walkie-talkies and pay them an annual tax. Some other demands were also made. After the meeting, Kidwai met Sehgal and briefed him about the discussion. The minutes of this meeting were submitted to Krishna Kumar who sent a copy of it to Ratan, who once again reiterated the group policy not to yield in any manner to the militants' demands.

On 11 June, Tata Tea reiterated the position it had taken in Bangkok, expressing its inability to accede to the demands that ULFA had made. After a week, Krishna Kumar received a phone call from Baruah enquiring about the status of their demands. Wasting no time, he informed Ratan, who advised him to communicate that the group would not yield to them. Instead, he said that that the Tata Group would step up their welfare activities in the state. This included the introduction of a medical aid scheme. Three days later, Krishna Kumar sent Baruah a reply reiterating the company's decision.

Worsening Ties

In the 1996 state elections, Mahanta was once again voted to power. His victory did not bode well for the Tata Group. Tata Tea's relations with the government soured.

The Mahanta government believed that in 1990, Tata Tea had lobbied with the Central government to dismiss the state government. But Krishna Kumar dismissed this allegation as baseless.